



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Seven Oaks Classical School
School Website: <https://sevenoaksclassical.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Seven Oaks Classical School (Ellettsville, IN 47429) presents a deliberately classical public charter model with a strong emphasis on virtue, character formation, and a liberal-arts curriculum. Publicly marketed as a school of choice with a focus on "Whole-Child Formation" and a Hillsdale College aligned K-12 program, the school declares adherence to classical ideals while explicitly stating it is not a religious school. This combination yields a mixed classical signal: substantively classical in goal and culture, yet lacking in explicit theological or liturgical programming. Overall, the school earns a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation, with notable strengths in formation, virtue, and classical curricular aims, but lacking explicit, publicly stated doctrinal or liturgical foundations and some traditional pedagogy signals (e.g., explicit all-lane Socratic inquiry and Great-Books-anchored Great Conversation as campus-wide practice).

Key insights: - Public charter status with Hillsdale-supported, classical K-12 curriculum; strong emphasis on virtue, character, and formation beyond mere information transfer. - Explicit statements about neutrality on religion, while foregrounding classical aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and moral formation as primary goals. - Curriculum signals include liberal-arts emphasis, Latin, Western tradition, and a Lyceum program hinting at dialogue between ancient wisdom and modern science; however, explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framing is not consistently stated in public materials. - Pedagogical signals are partial: some elements suggest contemplative or non-mechanical learning, while explicit Socratic seminars or full upper-school rhetoric training are not consistently documented on public pages. - Strong faculty signals (Master Teachers; Hillsdale alignment) and robust parent/community engagement posture.

Evidence and category-by-category analysis below uses keyword mapping to the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School, drawing on both the public site content and the knowledge-base rubrics.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials explicitly state the school is not religious: "No. Seven Oaks Classical School is a public school. As such, it has neither a religious identity nor a religious mission." World religions may be discussed academically, but the aim is to inform, not proselytize. - The classical education rationale is framed around transcendent ideals: "A classical education is an education aimed at human excellence... orient students' minds and affections to the true, the beautiful, and the good." This aligns with transcendental moral realism in the Six Elements framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: true, beautiful, good (the triad in the "true, the beautiful, and the good" phrase); virtue; character; moral formation; formation; wisdom. These map to

the Positive Keywords for Transcendental Truth/Goodness/Beauty and virtue formation in the Six Elements doc. - Negative keywords present: explicit religious identity or mission is denied (i.e., not religious). This corresponds to the Negative/guarded signals in the document's framework about religious grounding.

Why this rating - The school foregrounds transcendental ideals (truth, beauty, goodness) but explicitly disavows religious identity and liturgical practice; there is no theology-centered or liturgical dimension publicly claimed. This yields partial alignment with the foundational element—transcendental moral realism is present, but theology and liturgical/community practices are not. The balance tips toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Score justification notes from the Six Elements framework - The presence of “true, good, beautiful” and “virtue/character formation” supports the transcendental moral realism and formation components, but the absence of theological or liturgical grounding keeps category 1 from CLASSICAL.

Cited sources: classical ends/true-beauty-good phrasing; explicit non-religious stance.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Whole-Child Formation: “We educate both mind and heart — teaching rigorous academics alongside virtues like honesty, respect, perseverance, and service. Our goal is not just to prepare students for a career, but for a meaningful life.” This language explicitly emphasizes formation, virtue, and human excellences over mere job preparation. - The public-facing mission emphasizes training minds and improving hearts through a rigorous classical education in the liberal arts and sciences, with instruction in moral character and civic virtue. This aligns with a formation-first objective, not solely vocational preparation.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, character, moral formation, honesty, respect, perseverance, service, human excellence, civic virtue, truth/beauty/good (reflected in the underlying classical rationale). - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials (there is no claim of job-preparation as the primary goal; the site explicitly contrasts with vocation-centric aims).

Why this rating - Evidence shows a purpose anchored in formation, moral/character development, and the cultivation of human excellence rather than mere work-readiness. The school adopts a traditional virtues-based aim aligned with classical pedagogy, yielding CLASSICAL for Element 2.

Cited sources: Whole-Child Formation language and mission framing.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Liberal Arts foundation and curriculum scope: “The mission of Seven Oaks Classical School is to train the minds and improve the hearts of young people through a rigorous classical education in the liberal arts and sciences, with instruction in the principles of moral character and civic virtue.” This indicates a liberal-arts curriculum rooted in classical aims. - Foundational emphasis on languages, fine arts, and sciences: The site states a strong foundation in languages, fine arts, and sciences, signaling a broad liberal-arts approach. - Latin emphasis and Western tradition: The curriculum highlights Latin study and Western cultural literacy, signaling discipline-specific classical strands. - The Lyceum program signals an emphasis on conversation between ancient wisdom and modern science (potentially aligning with Great Conversation).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, languages, fine arts, sciences; classical education; Latin; Western tradition; Great Conversation (via Lyceum concept); Master Teacher program (supporting a classical pedagogy). - Negative keywords present: explicit reference to Great Books/Great Conversation as a formal, campus-wide Great Books program is not consistently stated on public pages (though Lyceum hints at classical dialogue). This reduces the strength of the Great Books/Great Conversation signal in public materials.

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly anchored in liberal-arts and classical aims (languages, Western tradition, and a Lyceum-style dialogue concept), but there is less explicit, consistent public-facing language about Great Books as a formal, campus-wide Great Conversation program or a full trivium/quadrivium framing. This partial alignment places Element 3 in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Cited sources: curriculum overview, language/Latin emphasis, Western tradition, Lyceum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public pedagogy signals include a mix of traditional and modern approaches (Hillsdale-aligned K-12 model) and emphasis on forming minds and hearts, not just drilling content. The public materials emphasize disciplined, values-driven learning and a blend of traditional and cutting-edge techniques. - The Lyceum and School events indicate opportunities for Socratic-style exchange and dialogue (the Lyceum tagline mentions “a conversation between ancient wisdom and modern science”). This suggests exposure to dialogic pedagogy in some contexts. - There is no consistently explicit statement of formal Socratic seminars or upper-school rhetoric training on public pages; the presence of the Hillsdale partnership and specific master-teacher programs implies a strong, teacher-led, standards-based framework rather than a pure Socratic method across all grades. Public pages do not consistently claim “Socratic discussions” as a universal method. The absence of explicit, campus-wide statements about Socratic seminars or debates is notable.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplative/restful learning signals are not strongly asserted, but “formation” and “character” imply holistic pedagogy; “Socratic” language appears only in specific program contexts (Lyceum) rather than as a campus-wide teaching method. The Great Conversation/socratic-style signals exist but are not uniformly described across grade levels in public materials. - Negative keywords present: lack of explicit, school-wide Socratic pedagogy or project-based/experiential-learning signals in public pages; absence of a consistent “Socratic discussion in upper school” claim.

Why this rating - The school shows classical alignment in formational aims and occasional dialogic opportunities, but public-facing pedagogy signals are not uniformly explicit (especially compared with explicit Socratic/great-books pedagogy signals in other classical schools). This results in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Cited sources: Lyceum (dialogue concept), Hillsdale-aligned pedagogy, and absence of universal Socratic claims on public pages.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Master Teacher program and Hillsdale alignment: The school is connected with Hillsdale College’s K-12 Education Office, including Master Teachers and a formal recognition program. This signals a faculty model anchored in high professional standards and classical pedagogy. - Faculty as living curriculum and core community: The site notes a national recognition of faculty and describes teachers as “content-area experts” with a focus on moral character and high standards; there are explicit calls for teachers who love learning and who model virtue for students. - School leadership and “Headmaster” visibility: Public pages introduce the Head of School and administration, highlighting a structured leadership model around virtue, discipline, and academic rigor. - Public statements of teacher quality and recruitment: The public-facing admissions and staff pages describe a professional, virtuous faculty profile and a system that prizes teacher expertise and character.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Master Teacher, Hillsdale K-12, living curriculum, faculty as core, expert teachers, virtuous modeling, headmaster, administration team. - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials (no explicit negative signals about faculty).

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of master teachers, Hillsdale-supported faculty development, and a philosophy that the faculty constitutes the living curriculum strongly align with CLASSICAL. Element 5 is CLASSICAL.

Cited sources: Master Teachers, Hillsdale alignment, faculty as living curriculum.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Active parent/community engagement: The site highlights “Community Coffee: Parent & Community Engagement,” signaling deliberate parent involvement and educational engagement opportunities beyond the classroom. - Family partnership language: The school emphasizes partnerships among families, teachers, and peers, and notes that families are encouraged to visit and participate in campus life. - Admissions and Shadow Day orientation: Public materials describe a welcoming, open admissions process and opportunities for parents to engage via tours and shadow days (community and parental involvement signals).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: parent partnerships, co-teaching with parents, community engagement, shadow day, campus visits, family involvement. - Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials (no explicit barriers to parent involvement).

Why this rating - The school promotes robust parent/community engagement and invites parent involvement, aligning with the classical expectation of an engaged community and co-teaching dynamic. Element 6 is CLASSICAL.

Cited sources: Community engagement piece; parent-teacher partnerships; admissions visits.

What Would Move the Needle

- Public articulation of a more explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framework across the full K-12 program (not just the Lyceum/programmatic hints). This would strengthen Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy) by codifying a universal Great Conversation approach.
 - Clear, campus-wide description of Socratic or seminar-based pedagogy in upper grades, including structured opportunities for Socratic dialogue and debates, to strengthen Element 4.
 - Explicit integration of Sabbath-like or liturgical/sacred rhythms (even if non-denominational) to bolster Element 1’s religious/metaphysical dimension, provided the school intends to maintain its non-religious stance publicly. If a liturgical dimension remains off the table, consider more explicit discussion of how virtue and moral formation are cultivated across disciplines to fortify Element 1 in a non-theological sense.
 - A public, documented articulation of the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and quadrivium in the curriculum, with examples of how those stages appear in K-12 coursework, to enhance Element 3.
 - More frequent, public-facing references to the Great Books canon, Great Conversation, and primary source engagement to strengthen Element 3 and align more closely with Six Elements expectations.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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